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alumni from the IITs and the IIMs are associated, to invest in companies emerging from these institutions. Of course, there is nothing exclusive about either the investee companies or the investors. We are not saying that the IITs and the IIMs enjoy an exclusivity with us; in fact, a majority of our members are not from these institutes. But yes, these institutes are our focus. We have our meetings in the IITs and IIMs, and we are involved with their entrepreneurship development cells or incubators. The simple logic is that investors are not interested in merely investing in the name of any institute, although that can be an advantage sometimes. An investor is more focused on interesting ideas.

Investees also do not want to restrict themselves to just the alumni. Angel investing is not just about funding — it is about mentoring, offering knowledge value-addition and about connections as well. For the start-ups, business exposure is as important as funds, to grow the business. So, we just don't arrange funds, we arrange for support in terms of mentorship, guidance and business exposure.

### Q How many start-ups have you funded so far?

A. We have completed the investment process in two start-ups, as of now. There are two more companies that we are in the advanced stages of funding. A couple of them are in the pipeline. Getting funds and appropriate mentorship for any start-up takes time. We had set up Lead Angels in July 2013. Our first angel meeting happened in October 2013 in Mumbai. It takes time to build a sizable network of like-minded people that can help

in investing in the companies. Right now, we have 70 investors on board as members, across Delhi, Mumbai and Ahmedabad.

### Q So, are you focusing only on tech start-ups?

A. No, not necessarily. As an investor, one doesn't want to be limited to any particular sector. One wants to invest in anything and everything that makes a profit. Of course, I won't deny that tech and tech-enabled businesses are a major attraction, because they are scalable. But we are not restricting ourselves or our investors to any domain. We are evaluating everything—from concept fast food restaurants to the healthcare sector. We cannot deny that today IT is an integral part of everything we want to do.

### Q As you mentioned, IT is an integral part of any business these days. Do you help the start-ups develop their IT infrastructure?

A. Before I answer that, let me share with you who our members are. They include people who have built successful businesses over a period of time like Faisal Farooqui of Mouthshut.com, Alok Kejriwal of Games To Win, etc. Some of the members are from traditional industries, like one of the founders of Lawrence and Mayo. There are also members working in private equity and venture capital firms, in their individual capacities. They bring the skills of what they do as investors to the network. So this network helps in evaluating the companies and when the investment is made, one of us becomes a board member or observer of the start-up to support and mentor the company, depending on what its critical requirements are.

Also, many of the investors in

the network are in a position to bring business to the start-ups. Let's not forget that for a start-up, getting that first order is the most important thing. So if we have a start-up that is into warehouse management, and one of our members is associated with a courier company that has a warehouse, it becomes easy for the start-up to get its first trial. The fact remains that nobody wants to give business to a start-up, but members do take such steps, helping the start-ups get their first order.

From the technology front, many of the members come with technical qualifications and experience. They can also help on technology if required. Since it is a group of experts in the business, they certainly know how to mentor and manage start-ups in more ways than one. We also have partnerships with multiple incubators like IIIT-Hyderabad, IIT-Delhi, IIT-Bombay and several such institutions. So, if a start-up requires some technical support or even interns, we can arrange all of that. Essentially we aim to provide support to the start-ups at various levels.

### Q Amongst the tech start-ups that you have worked with, so far, do you see open source technology flourishing?

A. Yes. In fact, one of the start-ups that we are looking at, which happens to be from Delhi, is using open source components to build a fairly complex product. I think that as the IT availability increases as a result of cloud and mobile technologies, it is creating a level playing field between start-ups and large companies. For example, the two competitors of this start-up are Fortune 100 companies. Their product would be similar to what this start-up is making. In fact, what these kids are creating is a faster product using open source technology and because it is going to be provided as a service, it will be easily and affordably available at any point in time. I am not claiming that